mujahideen intruded across the LoC in the Kargil sector upto a depth of six to eight kilometres, and occupied dominating heights in that rocky, barren and glaciated area. Some of them were wearing black Pathan suits as a measure to deceive the Indians, and came in through the unheld gaps. Historically, both sides considered such areas unviable for any worthwhile military operations, and consequently did not deploy troops to guard them. However, there were some posts that were occupied in summer and vacated in winter. It is worth mentioning that the average altitude of peaks in this area was in the region of 18,000 feet above sea level (see Sketches 17.1 and 17.2).

A first-hand account given by a Pakistani soldier who spent seventy-seven days in Indian territory in the Kargil area is recounted here:

> In the early days we mowed down many of them. Those Indians came like ants…. We also suffered a lot of casualties, many more than what officials in Pakistan are claiming…. The men who are fighting on those ridges know that they are in a hole from which they cannot come out alive.[2]

By attempting the unexpected, the Pakistani planners hoped to use surprise as a ploy and decided to launch this operation, named Badr, with the following objectives:

- Do a 'Siachen' on India, and thereby alter the status of the LoC for obvious gains. (Pakistan has not been able to live with India's pre-emptive securing of the Siachen area and thus planned to capture areas dominating National Highway 1A in an effort to interdict the road, and put pressure on India to vacate Siachen.)
- Internationalize the Kashmir issue.
- Give a boost to the flagging proxy war and terrorist activities in J&K.
- Isolate Turtok and Siachen by outflanking the Indian positions from the south.